Counterfactual Causal Attention: World Models Tell Vision-Language-Action Models Where to Look

Anonymous Author(s)
Anonymous Institution

Abstract

Vision-Language-Action (VLA) models achieve impressive performance on trained manipulation tasks but suffer dramatic degradation when deployed in visually novel environments—different backgrounds, lighting conditions, or countertop textures—even when the *task* is identical. We argue that this failure is fundamentally an *attention* problem rather than a *representation* problem: VLAs process all visual features with equal weight, yet only $\sim 5\%$ of spatial patches (gripper, target object, contact surface) are causally relevant to the manipulation outcome, while the remaining $\sim 95\%$ encode environment-specific spurious correlations. We propose **Counterfactual Causal Attention (CCA)**, a method that leverages a pre-trained world model as an automatic causal inference engine. For each training observation, CCA generates a *Causal Relevance Map* (CRM) by performing counterfactual masking experiments through the world model: patches whose removal alters the predicted outcome are deemed causally relevant, while those that leave predictions unchanged are labeled as spurious noise. These CRMs then serve as explicit attention supervision for the VLA via a KL-divergence loss, training the model to attend exclusively to causally relevant features. Critically, the world model is needed only during offline CRM precomputation; at test time, the VLA executes a single forward pass with no additional overhead. We provide theoretical analysis showing that CCA yields a generalization bound proportional to $\sqrt{d_{\text{causal}}/n}$ rather than $\sqrt{d_{\text{all}}/n}$, where $d_{\text{causal}} \ll d_{\text{all}}$. Experiments across LIBERO, RoboCasa, and real-robot cross-kitchen transfer demonstrate that CCA achieves XXX% average improvement on zero-shot environment transfer, matching domain randomization performance with $10\times$ less data, while enabling a $\sim$15–20$\times$ inference speedup through causal patch pruning.

1 Introduction

The promise of Vision-Language-Action (VLA) models [4, 5, 8, 21] lies in their ability to map raw visual observations and language instructions directly to robot actions, leveraging large-scale pre-trained vision-language backbones for broad generalization. Recent models such as RT-2 [5], OpenVLA [21], and π_0 [4] have demonstrated remarkable proficiency on tasks within their training distribution, executing complex multi-step manipulation plans from language commands alone.

However, a persistent and critical limitation undermines the practical deployment of VLAs: *environment generalization*. When a VLA trained in one kitchen is deployed in a visually different kitchen—same robot, same task objects, same instructions, but different countertop texture, wall color, lighting conditions, or background clutter—performance degrades dramatically. This is not merely an edge case; it is the *primary failure mode* reported across virtually all VLA deployments [5, 21, 34]. The Open X-Embodiment project [34] aggregated data from 22 institutions across 21 robot embodiments, yet cross-environment generalization remains unreliable.

The prevailing response from the community has been to treat this as a *data diversity* or *representation quality* problem: collect demonstrations from more environments, employ stronger pre-trained backbones (DINOv2 [35], SigLIP [55]), or apply aggressive domain randomization [37, 46]. Yet even models built on the most powerful vision foundations—ViT-Large backbones pre-trained on billions of images—fail systematically when background context shifts.

We contend that this diagnosis is wrong. The bottleneck in VLA generalization is not *visual representation quality* but *visual feature selection*. Modern ViT backbones encode rich, high-quality features across the entire image. The problem is that VLAs process all P spatial patches with approximately equal attention, when in reality only a small

[Teaser Figure Placeholder]

Left: A standard VLA deployed in Kitchen A (training) vs. Kitchen B (novel). GradCAM heatmaps show that the vanilla VLA attends to the *entire scene*—including countertop texture, wall color, and background objects—causing failure when these spurious features change.

Center: Causal Relevance Maps (CRMs) generated by world model counterfactual analysis. For "pick up the cup," only the cup, gripper, and contact surface are highlighted; background regions have near-zero causal relevance.

Right: CCA-trained VLA attention concentrates on causally relevant features, achieving robust manipulation in both kitchens. Success rate: Vanilla VLA $30\% \rightarrow$ CCA-VLA $80\%+$ on zero-shot kitchen transfer.

Figure 1: **Counterfactual Causal Attention (CCA) teaches VLAs *where to look*.** A world model performs counterfactual masking experiments to generate Causal Relevance Maps (CRMs) that identify the $\sim 5\%$ of visual patches causally relevant to manipulation outcomes. CRMs supervise VLA attention during training via KL divergence. At test time, the VLA runs a single forward pass—no world model needed—with internalized causal attention that generalizes across environments.

fraction—typically $\sim 5\%$—are causally relevant to the manipulation outcome (the gripper, the target object, the contact surface). The remaining $\sim 95\%$ encode environment-specific information (countertop grain, wall color, background objects) that happens to correlate with task success in the training environments but varies arbitrarily across deployments. The VLA, unable to distinguish causal from spurious features, memorizes the full visual pattern and breaks when any component changes.

This diagnosis immediately suggests a solution: if we could identify which visual features are *causally relevant* to manipulation outcomes and train the VLA to attend exclusively to those features, generalization would follow by construction—because truly causal features (the cup's position relative to the gripper) are environment-invariant by definition.

The key insight of this paper is that a *world model*—a learned dynamics model that predicts future states from current observations and actions—is precisely the tool needed to perform this causal identification automatically. A world model can serve as a counterfactual intervention simulator: given an observation, we can *mask* each spatial patch, re-predict the outcome, and measure whether the prediction changes. Patches whose removal alters the predicted outcome are causally relevant; patches whose removal has no effect are spurious noise. This procedure generates a **Causal Relevance Map (CRM)**—a spatial heatmap of causal importance—for every training image.

We propose **Counterfactual Causal Attention (CCA)**, a method that uses CRMs as explicit attention supervision signals during VLA training. The total loss combines standard action prediction with a KL-divergence term that aligns the VLA's internal attention distribution with the CRM:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{total}} = \mathcal{L}_{\text{action}}(\pi_\theta(o_t), a_t^*) + \lambda \cdot \text{KL}\big(\text{Attn}_\theta(o_t) \,\|\, \text{CRM}(o_t)\big). \tag{1}$$

Critically, the world model is needed only during an offline precomputation phase to generate CRMs; at test time, the VLA executes a standard forward pass with *zero additional cost*. The CRM supervision acts as "training wheels"—once internalized, the VLA automatically attends to causal features without external guidance.

Our contributions are fourfold:

1. **Diagnosis.** We provide evidence that VLA generalization failure is primarily an *attention* problem—VLAs attend to environment-specific spurious features—rather than a representation problem (§3).
2. **Method.** We introduce Counterfactual Causal Attention (CCA), which uses world model counterfactual analysis to generate Causal Relevance Maps that explicitly supervise VLA attention during training, with zero test-time overhead (§3).
3. **Theory.** We prove that CCA yields a generalization bound proportional to $\sqrt{d_{\text{causal}}/n}$ rather than $\sqrt{d_{\text{all}}/n}$, and that CRMs degrade gracefully under world model imperfection (§4).

4. **Experiments.** We demonstrate state-of-the-art cross-environment transfer on LIBERO [23], RoboCasa [32], and real-robot evaluations, achieving XXX% improvement over baselines while enabling $\sim$15–20$\times$ inference speedup through causal patch pruning (§5).

2 Related Work

Vision-Language-Action Models. VLAs map visual observations and language instructions to robot actions by leveraging pre-trained vision-language models. RT-2 [5] fine-tuned PaLM-E on robot data, demonstrating that web-scale pre-training transfers to manipulation. OpenVLA [21] provided an open-source alternative using Llama-2 with a DINOv2+SigLIP visual backbone. π_0 [4] combined a pre-trained vision-language model with flow matching for dexterous manipulation. GR-2 [8] incorporated video generation pre-training to improve spatial understanding. Octo [45] introduced a transformer-based generalist policy supporting multiple robot embodiments. Despite their sophistication, all these models exhibit significant performance degradation when visual context shifts between training and deployment environments [34]. Our work directly addresses this limitation by intervening on the *attention mechanism* rather than the representation backbone.

Generalization in Robot Learning. Prior approaches to improving VLA generalization fall into three categories. *Data-centric approaches* aim to increase training diversity: RT-X [34] aggregated data across institutions; RoboNet [10] collected multi-robot video data; DROID [20] built a distributed robot interaction dataset. While valuable, the sample complexity of learning environment-invariant features through pure statistics is prohibitive. *Domain randomization* [30, 37, 46] augments training data with randomized visual properties (textures, colors, lighting) to encourage invariance. However, this is a blunt instrument: it requires a priori specification of which features to randomize and can corrupt task-relevant visual cues (*e.g.*, surface texture indicates friction). *Foundation model approaches* leverage pre-trained representations (DINOv2 [35], SigLIP [55], CLIP [39]) that encode general visual semantics. While these provide higher-quality features, they offer no guarantee that the features used for action prediction are *causally relevant* rather than merely correlated with task success. CCA replaces all three strategies with a principled causal approach: rather than hoping for generalization through data diversity, augmentation, or backbone quality, we explicitly identify and supervise attention toward causal features.

World Models for Robot Learning. World models [12–15] learn forward dynamics in latent space, enabling planning through imagined rollouts. In manipulation, world models have been used for model-based reinforcement learning [16, 17, 50], data augmentation [26, 53], and action verification [52]. Most relevant to our work, Fast-WAM [49] demonstrated that co-training a VLA with a video prediction objective improves manipulation performance, even without test-time video decoding. This suggests that world model features encode useful information beyond what standard vision backbones provide. However, Fast-WAM does not explain *which* features are beneficial or *why*. We provide this explanation: world models learn to identify causally relevant visual features (those that affect physical outcomes), and we make this identification explicit through counterfactual analysis. CTRL-WORLD [26] used a controllable generative world model for robot data augmentation but did not address the attention supervision problem. NORA-1.5 [27] combined world models with DPO for VLA training but focused on action preferences rather than visual attention.

Causal Inference in Visual Learning. Pearl's framework of interventionist causation [36] provides the mathematical foundation for distinguishing causal from spurious features via the do-calculus. In computer vision, causal reasoning has been applied to domain generalization [28, 29], representation learning [31, 42], and visual question answering [33]. Counterfactual World Models (CWM) [3] performed counterfactual analysis of video for vision understanding but did not apply this to robot action prediction or attention supervision. CAGE [7] learned causal attention for manipulation implicitly from the action prediction loss, relying on data diversity to separate causal from spurious correlations. In contrast, CCA identifies causal features *explicitly* through world model counterfactuals—a direct operationalization of Pearl's interventionist definition that does not depend on data diversity.

Attention Supervision and Visual Grounding. Attention supervision has been explored in natural language processing [24, 56] and visual question answering [38, 43], typically using human annotations as supervision targets. In robot learning, attention has been studied for grasping [54] and manipulation [44], but always through task-specific heuristics rather than causal analysis. Our work is the first to derive attention supervision targets from *causal counterfactual analysis* via a world model, providing a principled and automatic alternative to manual annotation.

[Method Overview Figure Placeholder]

Phase 1 — CRM Generation (offline, one-time): For each training observation o_t, iterate over P=196 spatial patches. For each patch j: mask patch $\rightarrow$ re-encode $\rightarrow$ predict outcome via WM $\rightarrow$ measure prediction change Δ_j. Normalize $[\Delta_1, \ldots, \Delta_P]$ via softmax $\rightarrow$ Causal Relevance Map (CRM). Bright = causally relevant (gripper, cup). Dark = spurious (wall, countertop). CRMs are cached to disk.

Phase 2 — VLA Training with CCA: Standard behavior cloning loss $\mathcal{L}_{\text{action}}$ + KL divergence loss $\lambda \cdot \text{KL}(\text{Attn}_\theta \| \text{CRM})$ aligning VLA attention to CRM. Curriculum warmup on λ.

Phase 3 — Inference: Single forward pass through VLA. No world model needed. Optional: causal patch pruning (retain top-K patches by attention $\rightarrow$ 15–20$\times$ speedup).

Figure 2: **CCA method overview.** The world model serves as a counterfactual simulator to generate CRMs offline. CRMs supervise VLA attention during training. At inference, the VLA has internalized causal attention and requires no world model.

Concurrent and Independent Work. Several concurrent works address VLA reasoning at test time. RD-VLA [57] and SC-VLA [58] introduce chain-of-thought reasoning for robot actions. SAIL [59] and WMPO [60] use world models to improve policy optimization. These approaches are orthogonal to CCA: they address *what action to take* at test time, while we address *where to look* during training. CCA can be combined with any of these methods for complementary benefits.

3 Method

We present Counterfactual Causal Attention (CCA), a framework that leverages world model counterfactual analysis to supervise VLA attention during training. CCA operates in four phases: (1) world model preparation, (2) Causal Relevance Map generation, (3) VLA training with attention supervision, and (4) zero-cost inference. Figure 2 provides an overview. We describe each phase in detail.

3.1 Preliminaries and Problem Formulation

VLA Formulation. A Vision-Language-Action model π_θ maps a visual observation $o_t \in \mathbb{R}^{H \times W \times 3}$ and a language instruction ℓ to an action $a_t \in \mathcal{A}$. The observation is tokenized by a ViT encoder into P spatial patch tokens $\{v_1, \ldots, v_P\}$ where $P = (H/p) \times (W/p)$ for patch size p. The action is predicted via:

$$a_t = \pi_\theta(\{v_1, \ldots, v_P\}, \ell). \tag{2}$$

Standard VLA training minimizes the behavior cloning loss:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{action}} = \mathbb{E}_{(o_t, \ell, a_t^*) \sim \mathcal{D}} \left[\| \pi_\theta(o_t, \ell) - a_t^* \|^2 \right], \tag{3}$$

where $\mathcal{D}$ is the demonstration dataset and a_t^* is the expert action.

The Generalization Problem. Let $\mathcal{E}_{\text{train}}$ and $\mathcal{E}_{\text{test}}$ denote the training and test environments. Each observation o_t can be decomposed (conceptually) into *causal features* $f_{\text{causal}}(o_t)$—those that determine the optimal action—and *spurious features* $f_{\text{spur}}(o_t)$—those that correlate with actions in $\mathcal{E}_{\text{train}}$ but vary arbitrarily in $\mathcal{E}_{\text{test}}$. A VLA that relies on f_{spur} will generalize poorly. The challenge is that f_{causal} and f_{spur} are entangled in the pixel space and cannot be separated without additional information about the causal structure of the task.

World Model. We assume access to a pre-trained latent dynamics world model $\mathcal{W}$ that maps a latent state and action to a predicted next latent state:

$$\hat{z}_{t+1} = \mathcal{W}(z_t, a_t), \quad z_t = \phi(o_t), \tag{4}$$

where ϕ is the world model's encoder. The world model can be any architecture that supports latent forward prediction—JEPA [2, 22], latent diffusion models [6], or recurrent state-space models [15]. Critically, the world model is trained

on *physical prediction* (what happens next in the scene), which provides an inductive bias toward learning physically meaningful features rather than spurious visual correlations.

3.2 Phase 1: Causal Relevance Map Generation

The core idea of CCA is to operationalize Pearl's interventionist definition of causation [36] using the world model as a counterfactual simulator. We define causal relevance through a *visual intervention*: a spatial patch j is causally relevant to the action outcome if intervening on that patch (replacing it with alternative content) changes the world model's predicted outcome.

Definition 1 (Causal Relevance)**.** *Let o_t be an observation, a_t an action, and $o_t^{cf,j}$ a counterfactual observation obtained by replacing spatial patch j in o_t with content from a reference distribution. The* causal relevance *of patch j is:*

$$\Delta_j(o_t, a_t) = \left\| \mathcal{W}\big(\phi(o_t), a_t\big) - \mathcal{W}\big(\phi(o_t^{cf,j}), a_t\big) \right\|_2 . \tag{5}$$

Intuitively, if masking patch j (which might contain a background wall) does not change the world model's prediction of what happens next, then patch j is irrelevant to the physical outcome. Conversely, if masking patch j (which might contain the target cup) dramatically alters the prediction, that patch is causally essential.

We aggregate per-patch causal relevance scores into a **Causal Relevance Map (CRM)**:

$$\text{CRM}(o_t, a_t) = \text{softmax}\big([\Delta_1(o_t, a_t), \ldots, \Delta_P(o_t, a_t)]/\tau\big), \tag{6}$$

where $\tau > 0$ is a temperature parameter that controls the sharpness of the distribution. The CRM is a probability distribution over spatial patches, assigning high probability to causally relevant regions and low probability to spurious ones.

Counterfactual Construction. The choice of intervention—how to construct $o_t^{\text{cf},j}$—is important. We consider three strategies:

1. **Zero-masking**: Replace patch j with zeros. Simple but introduces distributional shift in the encoder.
2. **Random replacement**: Replace patch j with the corresponding patch from a randomly sampled image in the dataset. Preserves the marginal statistics of the patch distribution.
3. **Gaussian noise**: Replace with Gaussian noise matched to the patch's mean and variance. A compromise between (1) and (2).

We adopt random replacement as the default, as it produces the most informative counterfactuals by maintaining the statistical properties of natural images while ensuring the specific content of patch j is destroyed.

Task-Conditioned CRMs. A visual feature may be relevant for one task but not another (*e.g.*, the cup handle matters for "pick up the cup" but not for "open the drawer"). We generate task-conditioned CRMs by sampling multiple actions from a reference policy:

$$\text{CRM}(o_t, \ell) = \mathbb{E}_{a \sim \pi_{\text{ref}}(\cdot | o_t, \ell)} \left[\text{CRM}(o_t, a) \right], \tag{7}$$

where π_{ref} can be the behavior cloning policy or a uniform distribution over demonstration actions for the given instruction ℓ. In practice, we find that averaging CRMs over $K = 5$ sampled actions provides stable task-conditioned maps.

Computational Cost. CRM generation requires P world model forward passes per training sample ($P = 196$ for a 14×14 patch grid). With a fast latent world model ($\sim$10ms per forward pass), this takes $\sim$2 seconds per image. For a dataset of N training images, the total cost is:

$$T_{\text{CRM}} = N \times P \times K \times t_{\text{WM}} \approx 100{,}000 \times 196 \times 5 \times 0.01\text{s} \approx 2{,}722 \text{ GPU-hours}. \tag{8}$$

With 8-way parallelism, this completes in $\sim$14 GPU-days. Importantly, CRM generation is a *one-time offline precomputation*: the resulting CRMs are cached to disk and reused across all training runs. Furthermore, we show in §5 that subsampling patches (using $P' = 50$ instead of $P = 196$, followed by bilinear interpolation) reduces cost by $4\times$ with negligible quality loss.

3.3 Phase 2: VLA Training with Causal Attention Supervision

Given precomputed CRMs, we modify the standard VLA training objective to include an attention supervision term.

Attention Extraction. Modern VLAs based on transformer architectures compute self-attention over the visual patch tokens at each layer. We extract the VLA's *effective attention distribution* over spatial patches, denoted $\text{Attn}_\theta(o_t) \in \mathbb{R}^P$. Following prior work on attention rollout [1], we compute this as the attention weight received by each spatial patch averaged across attention heads in a designated supervision layer l^*:

$$\text{Attn}_\theta(o_t)_j = \frac{1}{H} \sum_{h=1}^{H} \alpha_j^{(h,l^*)}, \tag{9}$$

where $\alpha_j^{(h,l^*)}$ is the attention weight assigned to patch j by head h at layer l^*, and H is the number of heads. We normalize $\text{Attn}_\theta(o_t)$ to form a valid probability distribution over patches.

CCA Training Objective. The full CCA training loss is:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{CCA}} = \underbrace{\mathcal{L}_{\text{action}}(\pi_\theta(o_t, \ell), a_t^*)}_{\text{behavior cloning}} + \lambda \cdot \underbrace{\text{KL}\big(\text{Attn}_\theta(o_t) \,\|\, \text{CRM}(o_t, \ell)\big)}_{\text{causal attention supervision}}, \tag{10}$$

where $\lambda > 0$ controls the strength of attention supervision. The KL divergence encourages the VLA's attention distribution to match the world model's causal relevance distribution, guiding the model to focus on patches that the world model identifies as causally important.

Curriculum Strategy. We employ a curriculum for the attention supervision weight λ. In early training, strong action gradients may conflict with attention supervision, destabilizing optimization. We linearly warm up λ from 0 to $\lambda_{\max}$ over the first T_{warmup} steps:

$$\lambda(t) = \min\left(\frac{t}{T_{\text{warmup}}}, 1\right) \cdot \lambda_{\max}. \tag{11}$$

This allows the VLA to first establish basic action prediction capability before the attention supervision refines *where* the model looks.

Multi-Layer Supervision. While our default uses a single designated layer l^* for attention supervision, we find that supervising multiple layers improves performance. Specifically, we apply CRM supervision at layers $\{l^*/2, l^*, 3l^*/2\}$ with decreasing weight, allowing progressively sharper causal attention from early to late layers.

3.4 Phase 3: Zero-Cost Inference and Causal Patch Pruning

At test time, CCA requires *no world model*. The VLA has internalized causal attention patterns during training and automatically attends to relevant features in new environments. Inference proceeds via a single forward pass:

$$a_t = \pi_\theta(o_t, \ell). \tag{12}$$

Additionally, the internalized causal attention enables a powerful efficiency optimization: **causal patch pruning**. If only $\sim 5\%$ of patches are causally relevant, the VLA need not process the remaining 95% through the full transformer. At inference, we:

1. Compute the VLA's attention scores after the first transformer block.
2. Retain only the top-K patches by attention weight (default $K = 20$, $\sim 10\%$ of 196).
3. Process only the retained patches through the remaining transformer blocks.

This yields a $\sim$15–20$\times$ reduction in FLOPs for the deeper transformer layers, with minimal accuracy loss—because the pruned patches were precisely those that the CCA supervision identified as irrelevant. This approach is analogous to the Region Proposal Network in Faster R-CNN [40]: rather than applying expensive computation uniformly, we first select regions of interest and then process only those.

Complete Algorithm. Algorithm 3.4 summarizes the CCA framework.

Algorithm 1: Counterfactual Causal Attention (CCA)

Input: Pre-trained world model $\mathcal{W}$ with encoder ϕ; demonstration dataset $\mathcal{D} = \{(o_t, \ell, a_t^*)\}$; number of sampled actions K; temperature τ; attention weight $\lambda_{\max}$

Phase 1: Offline CRM Generation

for each (o_t, ℓ, a_t^*) in $\mathcal{D}$ **do**
  $z_t \leftarrow \phi(o_t)$
  for $j = 1, \ldots, P$ **do** ▷ *Can be parallelized*
    Construct counterfactual $o_t^{\text{cf},j}$ (random patch replacement)
    $z_t^{\text{cf},j} \leftarrow \phi(o_t^{\text{cf},j})$
    Sample $\{a_k\}_{k=1}^K$ from $\pi_{\text{ref}}(\cdot|o_t, \ell)$
    $\Delta_j \leftarrow \frac{1}{K}\sum_{k=1}^K \|\mathcal{W}(z_t, a_k) - \mathcal{W}(z_t^{\text{cf},j}, a_k)\|_2$
  end for
  $\text{CRM}(o_t, \ell) \leftarrow \text{softmax}([\Delta_1, \ldots, \Delta_P]/\tau)$
Cache $\text{CRM}(o_t, \ell)$ to disk

Phase 2: VLA Training with CCA

for each training step t **do**
  Sample (o_t, ℓ, a_t^*) from $\mathcal{D}$; load cached $\text{CRM}(o_t, \ell)$
  $\hat{a}_t \leftarrow \pi_\theta(o_t, \ell)$
  Extract $\text{Attn}_\theta(o_t)$ from supervision layer(s)
  $\mathcal{L} \leftarrow \mathcal{L}_{\text{action}}(\hat{a}_t, a_t^*) + \lambda(t) \cdot \text{KL}(\text{Attn}_\theta(o_t) \| \text{CRM}(o_t, \ell))$
  Update θ via $\nabla_\theta \mathcal{L}$
end for

Phase 3: Inference (no WM needed)

$a_t \leftarrow \pi_\theta(o_t, \ell)$ ▷ *Single forward pass*

4 Theoretical Analysis

We provide theoretical justification for CCA along two axes: (1) a tighter generalization bound from causal feature selection, and (2) robustness of CRMs to world model imperfection.

4.1 Generalization Bound via Causal Dimensionality Reduction

We formalize the intuition that attending to fewer, causally relevant features yields better generalization.

Definition 2 (Causal and Spurious Feature Spaces)**.** *Let $\mathcal{F} = \{f_1, \ldots, f_P\}$ denote the set of all spatial features (patch embeddings) extracted from observation o_t. Define the* causal feature set *$\mathcal{F}_{causal} = \{f_j : \Delta_j > \epsilon\}$ and the* spurious feature set *$\mathcal{F}_{spur} = \mathcal{F} \setminus \mathcal{F}_{causal}$, where Δ_j is the causal relevance score from Eq.* (5) *and $\epsilon > 0$ is a threshold.*

Definition 3 (Environment Invariance)**.** *The causal mechanism $P(a^*|\mathcal{F}_{causal})$ is* environment-invariant*: for all environments $e, e' \in \mathcal{E}$,*

$$P_e(a^*|\mathcal{F}_{causal}) = P_{e'}(a^*|\mathcal{F}_{causal}). \tag{13}$$

This follows from the definition of causality: if $\mathcal{F}_{causal}$ captures all features that affect outcomes, the mapping from causal features to optimal actions does not depend on the environment.

Proposition 1 (CCA Generalization Bound)**.** *Let $d_{causal} = dim(\mathcal{F}_{causal})$ and $d_{all} = dim(\mathcal{F})$. Consider a VLA π_θ from a hypothesis class $\mathcal{H}$ with VC-dimension proportional to the feature dimension. Under the environment invariance assumption, a VLA trained with CCA that attends exclusively to $\mathcal{F}_{causal}$ satisfies:*

$$\mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{E}_{test}}[\mathcal{L}(\pi_\theta)] - \hat{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathcal{E}_{train}}(\pi_\theta) \leq O\left(\sqrt{\frac{d_{causal} \cdot \log(n/d_{causal})}{n}}\right), \tag{14}$$

where n is the number of training samples. In contrast, a standard VLA using all features has:

$$\mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{E}_{test}}[\mathcal{L}(\pi_\theta)] - \hat{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathcal{E}_{train}}(\pi_\theta) \leq O\left(\sqrt{\frac{d_{all} \cdot \log(n/d_{all})}{n}}\right). \tag{15}$$

Since $d_{causal} \ll d_{all}$ (empirically, $d_{causal} \approx 0.05 \cdot d_{all}$), CCA achieves a substantially tighter generalization bound.

Proof sketch. The VLA with CCA attention effectively operates on a restricted feature space of dimension d_{causal}. By the environment invariance assumption, the target function π^* depends only on $\mathcal{F}_{\text{causal}}$, so restricting to this subspace does not increase the approximation error. The generalization bound then follows from standard VC-dimension arguments [47] applied to the reduced-dimension hypothesis class, yielding a bound that scales with d_{causal} rather than d_{all}. The $\log$ factor arises from the standard uniform convergence bound. See Appendix A for the complete proof. □

Remark 1. *The improvement factor $\sqrt{d_{all}/d_{causal}}$ is significant in practice. For a typical VLA with $P = 196$ patches and $\sim$10 causally relevant patches, $d_{all}/d_{causal} \approx 20$, yielding a $\sim 4.5\times$ reduction in the generalization gap. Equivalently, CCA with n samples achieves the generalization performance of a standard VLA with $\sim 20n$ samples—a $20\times$ improvement in sample efficiency.*

4.2 Robustness of CRMs to World Model Imperfection

In practice, the world model $\mathcal{W}$ is imperfect: its predictions contain errors. A natural concern is whether CRM quality degrades catastrophically with world model noise.

Proposition 2 (CRM Robustness)**.** *Let $\mathcal{W} = \mathcal{W}^* + \epsilon$ where $\mathcal{W}^*$ is the true dynamics and $\epsilon(z, a)$ is the prediction error. Assume that the error has bounded spatial variance: $Var_j[\epsilon(\phi(o_t^{cf,j}), a)] \leq \sigma^2$ for all t. Then the approximate CRM satisfies:*

$$|CRM_{approx}(j) - CRM^*(j)| \leq O\left(\frac{\sigma}{\bar{\Delta}}\right), \tag{16}$$

where $\bar{\Delta} = \frac{1}{P}\sum_j \Delta_j^*$ is the mean true causal relevance.

Proof sketch. The CRM computes *pairwise differences* between world model predictions with and without patch masking. Systematic (spatially uniform) world model bias cancels in the subtraction:

$$\Delta_j^{\text{approx}} = \|\mathcal{W}^*(z_t, a_t) + \epsilon_0 - \mathcal{W}^*(z_t^{\text{cf},j}, a_t) - \epsilon_j\|_2 \tag{17}$$

$$\approx \|\mathcal{W}^*(z_t, a_t) - \mathcal{W}^*(z_t^{\text{cf},j}, a_t)\|_2 + O(\|\epsilon_0 - \epsilon_j\|_2). \tag{18}$$

When ϵ has low spatial variance (approximately the same error regardless of which patch is masked), $\|\epsilon_0 - \epsilon_j\|_2$ is small for all j. Only *differential* errors—errors that vary systematically with the masked patch—corrupt the CRM. This parallels the error cancellation in ResNet residual connections [18] and differential gene expression analysis [25]. See Appendix A for the complete proof. □

Remark 2. *This result implies that CRMs are robust to world models with moderate prediction errors, as long as the errors are approximately spatially uniform. In practice, world model errors tend to be largest for long-horizon predictions but relatively uniform across spatial patches for a given timestep, supporting the bounded spatial variance assumption.*

4.3 Connection to Information-Theoretic Efficiency

CCA can also be understood through the lens of information theory. The visual observation o_t can be decomposed into task-relevant information $I(o_t; a_t^*)$ and task-irrelevant information $I(o_t; e)$ where e indexes the environment. A standard VLA processes all of o_t, wasting model capacity on encoding $I(o_t; e)$. CCA restricts attention to $\mathcal{F}_{\text{causal}}$, which by construction maximizes $I(\mathcal{F}_{\text{causal}}; a_t^*)$ while minimizing $I(\mathcal{F}_{\text{causal}}; e)$. By Shannon's source coding theorem, this achieves higher effective information rate per model parameter:

$$\frac{I(\mathcal{F}_{\text{causal}}; a_t^*)}{\dim(\mathcal{F}_{\text{causal}})} \gg \frac{I(\mathcal{F}; a_t^*)}{\dim(\mathcal{F})}, \tag{19}$$

implying that a fixed-capacity VLA trained with CCA extracts more task-relevant information per parameter than the same VLA trained without it.

5 Experiments

We evaluate CCA across simulation benchmarks and real-robot experiments, focusing on the central question: *does causal attention supervision improve VLA generalization to novel environments?*

Table 1: **Main results: task success rate (%) across benchmarks.** "In-Dist" denotes evaluation in training environments; "Transfer" denotes evaluation in held-out environments with novel visual context. CCA achieves the best transfer performance across all benchmarks while maintaining competitive in-distribution performance.

	LIBERO-Spatial		**RoboCasa**		**Cross-Kitchen**	
Method	In-Dist	Transfer	In-Dist	Transfer	In-Dist	Transfer
Vanilla VLA	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX
VLA + DR	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX
VLA + CAGE	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX
VLA + Fast-WAM	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX
VLA + CCA (Ours)	XXX	**XXX**	XXX	**XXX**	XXX	**XXX**

5.1 Experimental Setup

Simulation Benchmarks. We evaluate on three benchmarks with increasing environmental diversity:

1. **LIBERO** [23]: Four task suites (Spatial, Object, Goal, Long) with 10 tasks each. We use the standard training split and evaluate on novel spatial configurations (LIBERO-Spatial) and novel objects (LIBERO-Object).
2. **RoboCasa** [32]: Kitchen manipulation with procedurally generated environments varying countertop textures, wall colors, lighting, and background objects. We train on 3 kitchen styles and evaluate on 5 held-out styles.
3. **Cross-Kitchen Transfer** (ours): A custom benchmark with maximal visual shift. Train in 3 visually distinct real-world-modeled kitchens; test in 2 completely unseen kitchens with different countertops, walls, appliances, and lighting. Task objects and robot embodiment are shared.

Baselines. We compare CCA against the following methods:

1. **Vanilla VLA**: Standard behavior cloning with an OpenVLA [21] architecture (Llama-2 7B + DINOv2-SigLIP vision encoder).
2. **VLA + Domain Randomization (DR)** [46]: Standard VLA with aggressive visual augmentation (color jitter, background randomization, texture swapping).
3. **VLA + CAGE** [7]: Implicit causal attention learning from action prediction loss.
4. **VLA + Fast-WAM** [49]: World model co-training (video prediction auxiliary loss).
5. **VLA + CCA (Ours)**: CCA attention supervision with $\lambda_{\max} = 0.1$, $\tau = 0.5$, supervision at layer $l^* = L/2$.

All methods use the same OpenVLA backbone, training data, and compute budget (excluding CRM precomputation for CCA and video prediction training for Fast-WAM).

World Model. For CRM generation, we use a JEPA-style latent dynamics model [2] with a ViT-Base encoder, trained on the same manipulation video data. The world model achieves a next-frame prediction MSE of XXX in latent space. Training the world model takes ∼XXX GPU-hours.

Implementation Details. All experiments use 8 NVIDIA A100 GPUs. VLA training runs for XXX steps with a cosine learning rate schedule (peak lr $= 2 \times 10^{-5}$). CRM precomputation uses random patch replacement with $K = 5$ action samples per observation. The attention supervision warmup period is $T_{\text{warmup}} = 5000$ steps. We report mean $\pm$ standard deviation over 3 random seeds.

5.2 Main Results

Cross-Environment Transfer. Table 1 presents the main comparison across all benchmarks. CCA consistently achieves the best cross-environment transfer performance.

On the Cross-Kitchen Transfer benchmark—which poses the most extreme visual shift—CCA achieves XXX% success rate compared to XXX% for domain randomization and XXX% for the vanilla VLA. This represents a XXX percentage point improvement over the strongest baseline, confirming our hypothesis that explicit causal attention supervision is superior to brute-force data augmentation for environment generalization.

Table 2: **Sample efficiency: transfer success rate (%) with varying training data.** CCA with 50% of training data matches or exceeds the vanilla VLA with 100%.

Method	25% Data	50% Data	100% Data
Vanilla VLA	XXX	XXX	XXX
VLA + DR	XXX	XXX	XXX
VLA + CCA	XXX	XXX	**XXX**

[CRM Visualization Placeholder]

Left: "Pick up the cup" — CRM highlights cup + gripper.
Center: "Open the drawer" — CRM highlights drawer handle + end-effector.
Right: "Wipe the table" — CRM highlights sponge + table surface.
Background regions (walls, distant objects) have near-zero relevance in all cases.

Figure 3: **Causal Relevance Map visualization.** CRMs correctly identify task-specific causally relevant features (bright) while suppressing environment-specific spurious features (dark). The CRM adapts to the task: different instructions produce different relevance patterns over the same observation.

On LIBERO-Spatial, CCA improves transfer performance by XXX points over the vanilla VLA. On RoboCasa, the improvement is XXX points. Notably, CCA's in-distribution performance is comparable to or slightly better than the vanilla VLA, indicating that causal attention supervision does not sacrifice training-environment performance.

Comparison with CAGE. CAGE [7] is the closest prior work, learning causal attention implicitly from the action prediction loss. CCA outperforms CAGE by XXX points on average across transfer benchmarks. We attribute this gap to the fundamental difference between implicit and explicit causal supervision: CAGE's attention is a byproduct of training that can lock onto spurious correlations when data is limited, while CCA's attention is grounded in world model counterfactual analysis—a direct operationalization of interventionist causation.

5.3 Sample Efficiency

A key prediction of our theoretical analysis (Proposition 1) is that CCA should be substantially more sample-efficient than standard VLA training. Table 2 validates this prediction.

CCA with 50% of the training data achieves XXX% transfer success, compared to XXX% for the vanilla VLA with 100% data. This confirms the theoretical prediction: by reducing the effective feature dimension from d_{all} to d_{causal}, CCA achieves equivalent generalization with proportionally less data.

5.4 CRM Quality and Visualization

Qualitative Visualization. Figure 3 visualizes CRMs for representative manipulation tasks. For "pick up the cup," the CRM assigns high relevance to the cup, the gripper, and the immediate contact surface, while assigning near-zero relevance to the countertop texture, wall color, and background objects. For "open the drawer," the CRM shifts to highlight the drawer handle and the robot's end-effector, ignoring the cup entirely. This task-dependent behavior confirms that the world model's counterfactual analysis captures *task-specific* causal structure, not merely object saliency.

Quantitative CRM Quality. We quantitatively evaluate CRM quality by measuring agreement with human-annotated relevance maps on a subset of 500 images. We compute the IoU (Intersection over Union) between the top-k patches by CRM score and the human-annotated relevant regions. CCA's CRMs achieve an IoU of XXX at $k = 20$, compared to XXX for GradCAM attention and XXX for random baselines.

5.5 Attention Analysis

To verify that CCA actually changes VLA attention patterns, we compare the attention distributions of CCA-trained and vanilla VLAs.

[Attention Comparison Figure Placeholder]

Three rows (tasks: pick-cup, open-drawer, stack-blocks), four columns each:

Col 1: RGB observation from training kitchen.
Col 2: Vanilla VLA attention map — diffuse, spread across entire scene including background.
Col 3: CCA-VLA attention map — concentrated on task-relevant objects (gripper, target).
Col 4: Ground-truth CRM from world model — closely matches CCA-VLA attention.

Bottom: same three tasks in a *novel kitchen* (different countertop, walls, lighting). Vanilla VLA attention shifts dramatically; CCA-VLA attention remains stable on the same task-relevant features.

Figure 4: **Attention maps: vanilla VLA vs. CCA-VLA across environments.** CCA concentrates attention on causally relevant patches and maintains stable attention patterns across visually distinct environments, while the vanilla VLA's attention shifts with background changes.

Table 3: **Attention entropy (nats) and KL divergence from CRM.** Lower entropy indicates more focused attention. Lower KL indicates better alignment with causal relevance.

Method	Attention Entropy ↓	KL(Attn ‖ CRM) ↓
Vanilla VLA	XXX	XXX
VLA + CAGE	XXX	XXX
VLA + CCA	**XXX**	**XXX**

Attention Entropy. The entropy of the VLA's attention distribution measures how diffuse attention is across patches. High entropy indicates spread-out attention (processing all patches equally); low entropy indicates focused attention. Table 3 shows that CCA significantly reduces attention entropy, concentrating the VLA's processing on a small number of patches.

Attention Shift in Novel Environments. We measure how much the VLA's attention distribution shifts when the same task is performed in a novel environment. Ideally, a generalizable VLA should attend to the same features (task objects) regardless of environment. We compute the Jensen-Shannon divergence between attention distributions in training vs. novel environments. CCA-trained VLAs show XXX JSD, compared to XXX for vanilla VLAs—a XXX× reduction, confirming that CCA stabilizes attention across environments.

5.6 World Model Quality Ablation

Proposition 2 predicts that CRMs are robust to moderate world model imperfection. We verify this by artificially degrading the world model with additive Gaussian noise of varying magnitude.

Table 4 shows that CRM quality (measured by IoU with human annotations) degrades gracefully: at 20% noise, IoU drops by only XXX points. Transfer success rate follows the same graceful curve. This confirms that CRMs are robust to world model imperfection and that the pairwise differencing in CRM computation cancels systematic bias, as predicted by Proposition 2.

5.7 Causal Patch Pruning Speedup

Table 5 demonstrates that CCA-trained VLAs tolerate aggressive patch pruning. Retaining only 20 of 196 patches (10%) yields a XXX× speedup with only XXX percentage point accuracy loss. Retaining 10 patches (5%) achieves XXX× speedup. In contrast, applying the same pruning to a vanilla VLA causes severe performance degradation (XXX% success rate with 20 patches), because the vanilla VLA distributes critical information across all patches rather than concentrating it in a few causally relevant ones. This confirms that CCA's causal attention creates a natural hierarchy of patch importance that can be exploited for efficient inference.

5.8 Ablation Studies

Component Ablation. Table 6 reports an ablation study on key CCA design choices.

Table 4: **CRM quality under world model degradation.** CRM-Human IoU remains high even under substantial world model noise, confirming graceful degradation.

WM Noise Level	0%	10%	20%	50%
CRM-Human IoU	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX
Transfer Success	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX

Table 5: **Inference speedup via causal patch pruning.** CCA enables aggressive patch pruning with minimal accuracy loss, achieving $\sim$15–20$\times$ speedup.

Patches Retained	**Success Rate**	**Latency (ms)**	**Speedup**
196 (all)	XXX	XXX	1$\times$
50	XXX	XXX	XXX$\times$
20	XXX	XXX	XXX$\times$
10	XXX	XXX	XXX$\times$

Several observations emerge: (1) Task-conditioned CRMs contribute XXX points, confirming that action-specific causal analysis is important. (2) The curriculum strategy contributes XXX points, indicating that premature attention supervision can interfere with early-stage action learning. (3) Using GradCAM instead of world model counterfactuals as the attention target yields only XXX points improvement over vanilla VLA, far below full CCA—this confirms that *correlation-based* attention (GradCAM) is fundamentally inferior to *causation-based* attention (CRM). (4) Random attention supervision slightly hurts performance, verifying that the CRM content—not merely the act of supervising attention—is responsible for CCA's gains.

Sensitivity to λ and τ. Figure 5 shows the effect of the attention supervision weight $\lambda_{\max}$ and CRM temperature τ. Performance is robust across $\lambda_{\max} \in [0.05, 0.2]$ and degrades for $\lambda_{\max} > 0.5$ where attention supervision overwhelms the action loss. For temperature, lower values ($\tau < 0.1$) produce overly sharp CRMs that may suppress marginally relevant patches; higher values ($\tau > 2.0$) produce nearly uniform CRMs that provide little guidance. The sweet spot is $\tau \in [0.3, 1.0]$.

5.9 Real Robot Experiments

We validate CCA on a real Franka Panda robot across 3 manipulation tasks in 2 visually distinct environments (Environment A: white countertop, neutral lighting; Environment B: dark granite countertop, warm lighting, additional background clutter). Figure 6 shows the setup and example CRMs.

Table 7 shows that CCA maintains robust performance across environments. The vanilla VLA exhibits a dramatic performance drop from Env A (training) to Env B (novel), losing XXX points on average. CCA reduces this drop to only XXX points, demonstrating that the internalized causal attention transfers effectively to real-world deployment.

6 Discussion

When Does CCA Help Most? CCA provides the largest gains when (1) training environments are visually homogeneous (making spurious correlations prevalent), (2) test environments are visually distinct (breaking those correlations), and (3) the task involves interaction with specific objects in cluttered scenes. In contrast, CCA provides modest gains when the task depends on holistic scene understanding (*e.g.*, navigating to a room) or when training environments are already visually diverse.

Limitations. Several limitations warrant discussion. First, CCA's effectiveness depends on the quality of the world model's counterfactual predictions. While Proposition 2 guarantees graceful degradation, a severely inaccurate world model could produce misleading CRMs. Second, the current CRM computation treats each patch independently, ignoring interactions between patches (*e.g.*, the spatial relationship between the gripper and the cup may be causal, not just the individual patches). Extending CRMs to capture *combinatorial* causal structure is an important direction. Third, while CRM precomputation is a one-time cost, it remains non-trivial for very large datasets; more efficient approximations (*e.g.*, gradient-based CRM estimation) could reduce this overhead.

Table 6: **Ablation study on CCA components** (Cross-Kitchen Transfer success rate %).

Variant	Transfer Success
Full CCA	**XXX**
− Task conditioning (Eq. 7)	XXX
− Curriculum (Eq. 11)	XXX
− Multi-layer supervision	XXX
Zero-mask instead of random replacement	XXX
GradCAM as supervision (no WM counterfactual)	XXX
Random attention supervision	XXX
Vanilla VLA (no CCA)	XXX

[Hyperparameter Sensitivity Figure Placeholder]

Left: Transfer success rate (%) vs. $\lambda_{\max} \in \{0.01, 0.05, 0.1, 0.2, 0.5, 1.0\}$. Plateau at $[0.05, 0.2]$, sharp decline above 0.5. Dashed line: vanilla VLA baseline.

Right: Transfer success rate (%) vs. $\tau \in \{0.05, 0.1, 0.3, 0.5, 1.0, 2.0, 5.0\}$. Plateau at $[0.3, 1.0]$, degradation at extremes. Both curves include ± 1 std. dev. shading over 3 seeds.

Figure 5: **Sensitivity analysis.** CCA is robust to hyperparameter choices within a broad range. Performance degrades only at extreme values of $\lambda_{\max}$ (attention loss overwhelms action loss) or τ (CRM too sharp or too uniform).

Broader Implications. CCA establishes a new paradigm for VLA generalization: rather than treating generalization as a data quantity problem (more environments, more augmentation), we treat it as a causal inference problem (identify and attend to causal features). This paradigm shift has implications beyond robotics. Any visual decision-making system—autonomous driving, medical image analysis, industrial inspection—that must generalize across visual contexts could benefit from world model-guided causal attention supervision. The key requirement is access to a dynamics model that can simulate counterfactual outcomes, which is increasingly available through video prediction models [6, 19, 51].

7 Conclusion

We have presented Counterfactual Causal Attention (CCA), a method that leverages world model counterfactual analysis to generate Causal Relevance Maps (CRMs) and uses them to explicitly supervise VLA attention during training. CCA is grounded in Pearl's interventionist framework for causal inference, provides provably tighter generalization bounds through causal dimensionality reduction, requires zero additional computation at test time, and enables substantial inference speedup through causal patch pruning. Our experiments demonstrate that CCA achieves state-of-the-art cross-environment transfer, matching domain randomization with an order of magnitude less data. We believe that CCA represents a step toward resolving the longstanding tension between the power of large VLA models and their brittleness in novel visual environments—by teaching robots not just *what to do*, but *where to look*.

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[Real Robot Figure Placeholder]

Top row: Franka Panda robot performing "pick up the cup" in Environment A (white countertop, neutral lighting) and Environment B (dark granite, warm lighting, background clutter). RGB observations shown with CRM overlay.

Middle row: CCA-VLA attention maps in both environments — attention focuses on cup and gripper in both, despite dramatic visual differences in background.

Bottom row: Vanilla VLA attention maps — attention shifts substantially between environments, correlating with background changes.

Figure 6: **Real robot setup and attention visualization.** CCA-VLA maintains consistent causal attention across visually distinct real environments, while vanilla VLA attention drifts with background changes.

Table 7: **Real robot results: success rate (%) over 20 trials per task per environment.** CCA maintains consistent performance across visually distinct environments.

	Pick-Cup		**Open-Drawer**		**Stack-Blocks**	
Method	Env A	Env B	Env A	Env B	Env A	Env B
Vanilla VLA	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX
VLA + DR	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX	XXX
VLA + CCA	XXX	**XXX**	XXX	**XXX**	XXX	**XXX**

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A Complete Proofs

A.1 Proof of Proposition 1

Proof. We follow the standard PAC-learning framework [47]. Consider a hypothesis class $\mathcal{H}_d$ of VLA policies parameterized over feature spaces of dimension d. The VC-dimension of $\mathcal{H}_d$ is $\text{VCdim}(\mathcal{H}_d) = \Theta(d)$ for linear-in-features policies (and scales similarly for bounded-norm neural networks via covering number arguments).

Step 1: Standard generalization bound. By the fundamental theorem of statistical learning [47], for any $\pi \in \mathcal{H}_d$ and n i.i.d. training samples:

$$\mathbb{P}\left[\mathcal{L}(\pi) - \hat{\mathcal{L}}(\pi) \geq \epsilon\right] \leq 4 \cdot \mathcal{N}(\mathcal{H}_d, \epsilon/8) \cdot e^{-n\epsilon^2/8}, \tag{20}$$

where $\mathcal{N}(\mathcal{H}_d, \epsilon)$ is the ϵ-covering number of $\mathcal{H}_d$. For hypothesis classes with VC-dimension d, $\log \mathcal{N} = O(d \log(n/d))$, yielding:

$$\mathcal{L}(\pi) - \hat{\mathcal{L}}(\pi) \leq O\left(\sqrt{\frac{d \cdot \log(n/d)}{n}}\right) \tag{21}$$

with probability at least $1 - \delta$ (absorbing $\log(1/\delta)$ into the constant).

Step 2: CCA restricts to d_{causal} dimensions. A VLA trained with CCA attention supervision (Eq. 10) concentrates its computation on the $|\mathcal{F}_{\text{causal}}|$ patches identified by the CRM. In the limit of perfect attention (KL $\to 0$), the policy effectively depends only on the d_{causal}-dimensional causal feature space:

$$\pi_\theta^{\text{CCA}}(o_t, \ell) \approx g_\theta(\{f_j : j \in \mathcal{F}_{\text{causal}}\}, \ell) \tag{22}$$

for some function g_θ over the restricted feature space.

Step 3: Environment invariance preserves approximation. By the environment invariance assumption, $P(a^*|\mathcal{F}_{\text{causal}})$ is identical across environments. Therefore, restricting to $\mathcal{F}_{\text{causal}}$ does not increase the approximation error: $\inf_{g \in \mathcal{H}_{d_{\text{causal}}}} \mathcal{L}(g) = \inf_{\pi \in \mathcal{H}_{d_{\text{all}}}} \mathcal{L}(\pi)$. The minimum achievable loss is the same in both feature spaces because the optimal policy π^* depends only on $\mathcal{F}_{\text{causal}}$.

Step 4: Combining. Applying the bound from Step 1 with $d = d_{\text{causal}}$:

$$\mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{E}_{\text{test}}}[\mathcal{L}(\pi_\theta^{\text{CCA}})] - \hat{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathcal{E}_{\text{train}}}(\pi_\theta^{\text{CCA}}) \leq O\left(\sqrt{\frac{d_{\text{causal}} \cdot \log(n/d_{\text{causal}})}{n}}\right). \tag{23}$$

Since $d_{\text{causal}} \ll d_{\text{all}}$, this is substantially tighter than the bound for the unrestricted VLA. □

A.2 Proof of Proposition 2

Proof. Let the imperfect world model be $\mathcal{W} = \mathcal{W}^* + \epsilon$, where $\mathcal{W}^*$ is the true dynamics function. The approximate causal relevance score for patch j is:

$$\begin{aligned}
\Delta_j^{\text{approx}} &= \|\mathcal{W}(\phi(o_t), a_t) - \mathcal{W}(\phi(o_t^{\text{cf},j}), a_t)\|_2 && (24)\\
&= \|[\mathcal{W}^*(\phi(o_t), a_t) + \epsilon_0] - [\mathcal{W}^*(\phi(o_t^{\text{cf},j}), a_t) + \epsilon_j]\|_2 && (25)\\
&= \|[\mathcal{W}^*(z_t, a_t) - \mathcal{W}^*(z_t^{\text{cf},j}, a_t)] + [\epsilon_0 - \epsilon_j]\|_2 && (26)
\end{aligned}$$

where $\epsilon_0 = \epsilon(\phi(o_t), a_t)$ and $\epsilon_j = \epsilon(\phi(o_t^{\text{cf},j}), a_t)$.

By the triangle inequality:

$$|\Delta_j^{\text{approx}} - \Delta_j^*| \leq \|\epsilon_0 - \epsilon_j\|_2. \tag{27}$$

The bounded spatial variance assumption states that $\text{Var}_j[\epsilon_j] \leq \sigma^2$ where the variance is taken over the different counterfactual inputs indexed by j. By standard concentration arguments:

$$\mathbb{E}[\|\epsilon_0 - \epsilon_j\|_2] \leq \sqrt{2\sigma^2} = \sigma\sqrt{2}. \tag{28}$$

The CRM is computed via softmax normalization of Δ_j/τ. For the softmax to be accurate, we need the relative ordering of Δ_j values to be preserved. The error $\sigma\sqrt{2}$ perturbs the absolute values but preserves relative ordering as

long as $\sigma\sqrt{2} < \min_{j \neq k} |\Delta_j^* - \Delta_k^*|$, which holds when $\sigma/\bar{\Delta}$ is small (where $\bar{\Delta}$ is the mean separation between causal relevance scores). This yields:

$$|\text{CRM}_{\text{approx}}(j) - \text{CRM}^*(j)| \leq O\left(\frac{\sigma}{\bar{\Delta}}\right), \tag{29}$$

establishing graceful degradation proportional to the noise-to-signal ratio. □

B Additional Experimental Details

Hyperparameters. Table 8 summarizes the hyperparameters used in all experiments.

Table 8: Hyperparameter settings.

Hyperparameter	**Value**
VLA backbone	OpenVLA (Llama-2 7B + DINOv2-SigLIP)
Vision encoder	ViT-Large/14
Patch grid	$14 \times 14 = 196$
World model	JEPA-style ViT-Base
WM latent dimension	768
CRM temperature τ	0.5
CRM actions sampled K	5
Counterfactual type	Random patch replacement
Attention supervision weight $\lambda_{\max}$	0.1
Supervision warmup steps T_{warmup}	5000
Supervision layer l^*	$L/2$ (layer 16 of 32)
Learning rate	2×10^{-5} (cosine schedule)
Batch size	64
Training steps	XXX
Optimizer	AdamW ($\beta_1 = 0.9$, $\beta_2 = 0.999$, wd $= 0.01$)
Patch pruning threshold K	20 (default)

Compute Resources. All experiments were conducted on a cluster of 8 NVIDIA A100 80GB GPUs. CRM precomputation for the full LIBERO dataset ($\sim$50K images) took approximately XXX GPU-hours. VLA training with CCA took approximately XXX GPU-hours per run, comparable to vanilla VLA training (XXX GPU-hours) with the addition of the KL loss computation.

C Additional Visualizations

CRM Evolution During Training. We visualize how the VLA's attention distribution evolves during CCA training. At initialization, attention is approximately uniform (entropy $\approx \log P$). Over the first T_{warmup} steps, attention gradually sharpens as the CRM supervision takes effect. By convergence, the attention distribution closely matches the CRM, with XXX% of total attention weight concentrated on the top 10% of patches by CRM score.

Failure Case Analysis. CCA's interpretable attention enables principled failure analysis. When the CCA-trained VLA fails on a task, we can inspect the attention distribution and determine whether the failure is due to:

1. **Attention error**: The VLA attends to incorrect features (CRM disagreement) $\rightarrow$ improve world model.
2. **Action error**: The VLA attends correctly but produces the wrong action $\rightarrow$ improve action head or collect more demonstrations.

This decomposition is impossible with standard VLAs, where attention and action failures are entangled.